BYZANTINE–ARAB WARS

WHEN THE ARABS, inspired by the newly founded religion of Islam, embarked upon their campaigns of conquest around 630 CE, the Byzantine Empire was the dominant naval power in the Mediterranean. This status was swiftly challenged by the victory of an Arab fleet at the battle of the Masts in 655. Although the technologically innovative use of Greek fire helped the Byzantines drive back Arab ships from under the walls of Constantinople two decades later, the fall of Carthage to the Muslims at the end of the 7th century extended Arab sea power into the western Mediterranean. Fierce naval battles were fought over the following two centuries in struggles for control of major islands such as Sicily, Cyprus, and Crete. In the 11th and 12th centuries the strategic situation began to shift, with Turks replacing Arabs as the dominant force in the Muslim world and the Byzantines becoming increasingly dependent upon the navies of the Italian city-states of Genoa and Venice.

THE MEDITERRANEAN WORLD c.650—950

Following the conquest of Egypt in 639–646, it took Arab armies just 70 years to extend the lands of the Caliphate across North Africa into the Iberian Peninsula. Since the Arabs had no experience of seafaring, conquests by sea were less spectacular. In the east the Byzantine Empire remained a powerful block to Arab expansion, but in the 9th century the Byzantines were ejected from Sicily and Arab raids extended into Italy and the South of France, where Arab corsairs established bases.

KEY

- Abbasid Caliphate c.850
- Other Islamic states
- Byzantine Empire
- Arab invasion/ raid
- Arab victory
- Byzantine victory



ARAB EXPANSION IN THE MEDITERRANEAN

BATTLE OF THE MASTS



Date 655
Forces Byzantines: c.500 ships; Arabs: c.200 ships
Losses Byzantines: c.400 ships; Arabs: unknown

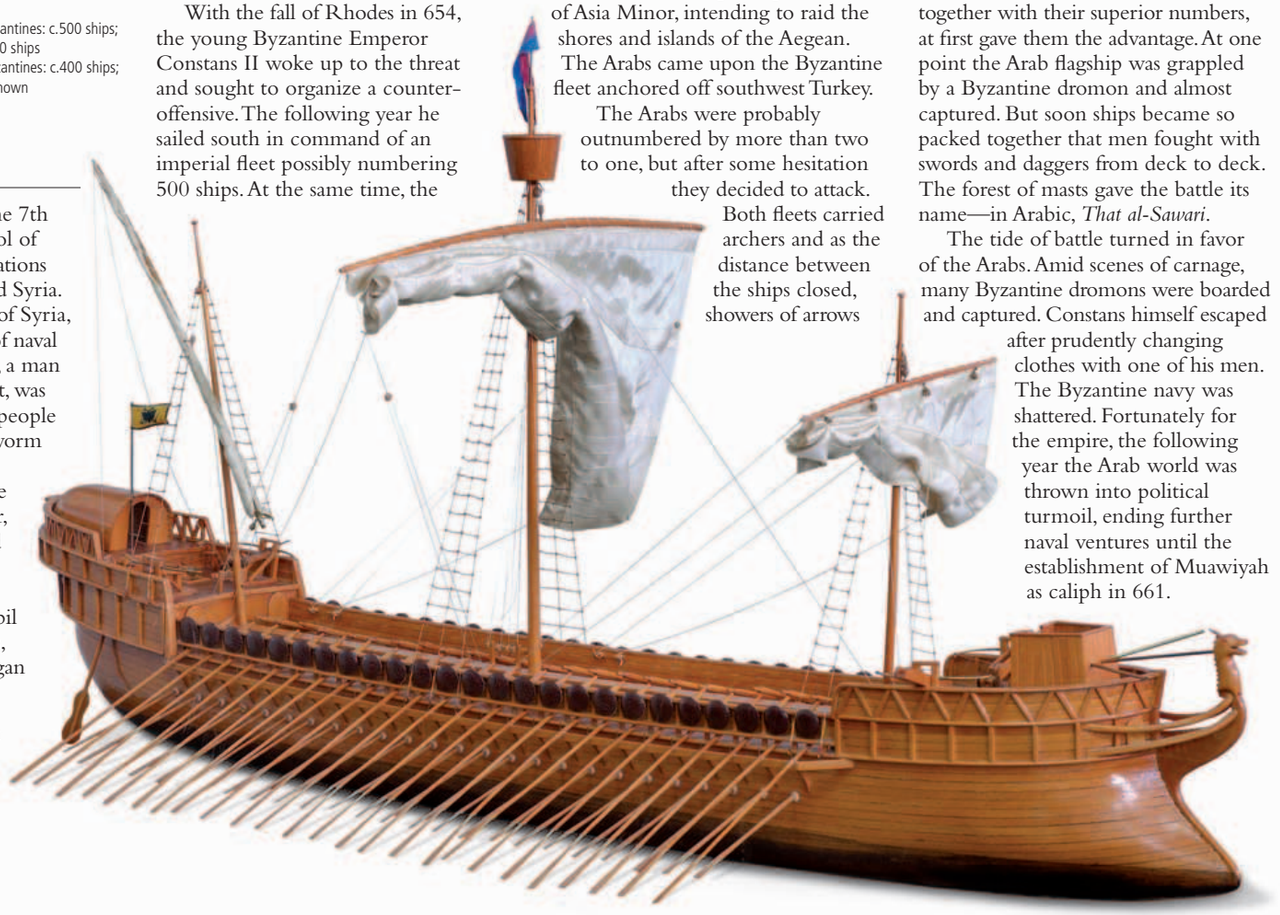
Location Off Lycia, southern Turkey

The Arab conquests of the 7th century gave them control of ports and seafaring populations on the coasts of Egypt and Syria. Muawiyah, the governor of Syria, urged the development of naval warfare but Caliph Omar, a man bred in the Arabian desert, was unconvinced, describing people on board ship as like "a worm in a log of wood." When Uthman succeeded to the caliphate in 644, however, Muawiyah was uthorized to develop a fleet, as was the governor of Egypt, Abdullah bin Saad bin Abil Sarh. This took two years, after which the Arabs began conquering or raiding Byzantine-ruled islands throughout the eastern Mediterranean.

With the fall of Rhodes in 654, the young Byzantine Emperor Constans II woke up to the threat and sought to organize a counter-offensive. The following year he sailed south in command of an imperial fleet possibly numbering 500 ships. At the same time, the combined Egyptian and Syrian fleets, under the command of Abdullah bin Saad, were advancing along the coast of Asia Minor, intending to raid the shores and islands of the Aegean. The Arabs came upon the Byzantine fleet anchored off southwest Turkey.

The Arabs were probably outnumbered by more than two to one, but after some hesitation they decided to attack. Both fleets carried archers and as the distance between the ships closed, showers of arrows fell upon both sides, causing substantial casualties. The Byzantine were more skilled in naval maneuver and this, together with their superior numbers, at first gave them the advantage. At one point the Arab flagship was grappled by a Byzantine dromon and almost captured. But soon ships became so packed together that men fought with swords and daggers from deck to deck. The forest of masts gave the battle its name—in Arabic, *That al-Sawari*.

The tide of battle turned in favor of the Arabs. Amid scenes of carnage, many Byzantine dromons were boarded and captured. Constans himself escaped after prudently changing clothes with one of his men. The Byzantine navy was shattered. Fortunately for the empire, the following year the Arab world was thrown into political turmoil, ending further naval ventures until the establishment of Muawiyah as caliph in 661.



Byzantine dromon
The word "dromon," which meant "swift runner," was applied to a range of ships, from small galleys to large biremes like the one shown here.